Jet Fuel Hits a Record Price, and Holiday Plane Tickets Are Soaring

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Planning to fly somewhere for the holidays? Get ready to pay more maybe a lot more.

The big reason is **jet fuel**, the special fuel airplanes burn, and one of the airline industry's biggest expenses. The average price of **jet fuel** in the United States reached $4.90 a gallon on Thursday, according to the tracking firm Argus. That is the highest single-day average the firm has ever recorded, and more than twice the price a year ago.

Airlines are passing part of that cost on to passengers. "**Airfares** right now are at what we see as a 10-year high because of the high cost of **jet fuel**," said Hayley Berg, the lead **economist** at Hopper, a travel tech company. According to Berg, Thanksgiving **airfares** are up about 30% compared with last year, and tickets for the Christmas holiday are up more than 20%.

Even so, travelers keep booking. Delta Air Lines CEO Ed Bastian said customers have shown a "limited amount of resistance" and still view airfare as "reasonably affordable." Chris Sununu, head of the **trade group** Airlines for America, said the airlines themselves are **absorbing** most of the extra fuel cost, but some of it "unfortunately has to be passed on to the customer."

People are adapting in different ways. Many booked their holiday trips earlier than usual this year, hoping to lock in prices before they rose. Others are skipping the plane entirely. Rachel Stern of Frederick, Maryland, said tickets for her and her kids cost too much, so she plans to drive to Chicago instead.

Some industry leaders think fares could climb further next year, especially in Europe. The picture may be slightly better in the United States, which has more oil-producing and **refining capacity** than Europe.

Word Treasure

jet fuel -- The special fuel that airplane engines burn to power flight.

airfares -- The prices passengers pay for plane tickets.

economist -- An expert who studies how money, prices and businesses work.

trade group -- An organization that speaks and acts for companies in the same industry.

absorbing -- In this story, it means paying a cost yourself instead of passing it on to someone else.

refining capacity -- How much crude oil a country is able to turn into usable fuels such as gasoline and jet fuel.

Background you need

Jet fuel is the special fuel that airplane engines burn, and it is one of the biggest costs an airline has.

When fuel prices rise, airlines often pass part of the extra cost on to passengers through higher ticket prices, especially at busy holiday times like Thanksgiving and Christmas, when many people want to fly.

Tracking firms and travel companies watch fuel prices and fares closely and report how they change compared with earlier years.

The United States produces and refines a great deal of its own oil, which can soften the effect of fuel price rises compared with places that import more.

Break it down

LEAD: Record jet fuel prices are pushing holiday airfares to a 10-year high

KEY EVENT: The average U.S. jet fuel price reached $4.90 a gallon on Thursday, the highest single-day average Argus has recorded

+- WHO: Airlines, travelers and the trade group Airlines for America

+- RESULT: Thanksgiving fares are up about 30% and Christmas fares more than 20% compared with last year

EVIDENCE: Delta's CEO says customers still see fares as reasonably affordable, while some families book earlier than usual or choose to drive

OPEN QUESTION: Will fares climb further next year, especially in Europe?

Why it matters

Millions of families fly to visit relatives over Thanksgiving and Christmas, so higher fares hit household budgets directly. The story also shows how the price of one fuel can ripple through the whole travel industry.

Test what you remember

1. What happened to the average price of jet fuel in the United States on Thursday?

(A) It doubled the price of every plane ticket overnight
(B) It stayed exactly the same as a year ago
(C) It fell to its lowest level in ten years
(D) It reached $4.90 a gallon, the highest single-day average Argus has ever recorded

2. Who said airfares are at a 10-year high?

(A) Ed Bastian of Delta Air Lines
(B) Hayley Berg, the lead economist at Hopper
(C) Chris Sununu of Airlines for America
(D) Rachel Stern of Frederick, Maryland

3. According to Berg, how much are Thanksgiving airfares up compared with last year?

(A) More than 20%
(B) About 30%
(C) About 10%
(D) More than half

4. What did Chris Sununu say airlines are doing about the extra fuel cost?

(A) Canceling holiday flights
(B) Asking passengers to bring their own fuel
(C) Passing all of it on to customers
(D) Absorbing most of it themselves, though some has to be passed on to the customer

5. Why did many travelers book their holiday trips earlier than usual this year?

(A) Because flights were about to sell out
(B) To earn extra travel rewards
(C) Because fuel prices were falling
(D) To lock in prices before they rose

6. What does Rachel Stern plan to do instead of flying?

(A) Fly on a cheaper date
(B) Stay home for the holidays
(C) Take a train to Chicago
(D) Drive to Chicago

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Hayley Berg, lead economist at Hopper: She says airfares are at a 10-year high because of the high cost of jet fuel.

2. Ed Bastian, CEO of Delta Air Lines: He says customers have shown a limited amount of resistance and still view airfare as reasonably affordable.

3. Chris Sununu, head of Airlines for America: He says airlines are absorbing most of the extra fuel cost themselves, but some of it unfortunately has to be passed on to the customer.

4. Rachel Stern, a traveler from Frederick, Maryland: She says tickets for her and her kids cost too much, so she plans to drive to Chicago instead of flying.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):